

TIDES OF KNOWING



The Discernment Checklist

21 Questions to Ask Before Pulling Another Card

A practical reader's checklist for recognising the right question, the cards carrying the answer, and the moment a tarot reading is complete.

THE DISCERNMENT SERIES

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OPENING

Introduction

Discernment in tarot is not about pulling more cards. It is about recognising the right question, identifying the cards carrying the answer, and knowing when a reading has reached completion.

This checklist is designed for both kinds of reading:

- Personal readings, where the reader is also the seeker.
- Readings for another person, where the seeker brings the question into the room.

Use these questions before, during, and after a reading to slow the process down, sharpen attention, and separate signal from noise.

The aim is not to make readings more complicated.
The aim is to make them cleaner.

OPENING

How to Use This Checklist

You do not need to answer every question every time.

This is a field guide, not a rulebook. Some readings need only one or two questions from the list. Others may benefit from a fuller pause, especially when the reading feels unclear, overworked, emotionally charged, or difficult to close.

Use the checklist when:

- The question does not feel settled.
- The cards make sense individually but not together.
- There is an urge to pull more cards.
- A reading begins repeating itself.
- The answer has landed but the reader keeps talking.
- The reading feels technically complete but emotionally unresolved.

The checklist is divided into three stages, each corresponding to one part of The Discernment Series:

- 1 Before the Reading
- 2 During the Reading
- 3 Closing the Reading

STAGE ONE · BEFORE THE READING

Is the Right Question in the Room?

Before any card is pulled, the quality of the question matters.

A reading can only answer the question that is actually present. If the spoken question is not the real question, the spread may produce static: cards that are individually clear but do not resolve into a coherent answer.

Use these questions before beginning.

- ☐ Is this the question that actually needs to be read?
- ☐ Is the seeker asking for clarity, reassurance, permission, confirmation, or avoidance?
- ☐ Is there another question underneath the one being spoken?
- ☐ Is the wording open enough to invite insight rather than force a narrow answer?
- ☐ What assumption is already sitting inside the question?
- ☐ Is the reading being asked too soon, before the situation has enough shape?
- ☐ If this reading could only answer one thing, what would that one thing need to be?

READER NOTE

Static is not always a failure of skill. Sometimes it is information. Before blaming the interpretation, check whether the question itself is tuned to the right frequency.

STAGE TWO · DURING THE READING

Has the Answer Already Arrived?

More cards do not automatically mean more clarity.

A reading has weight distribution. Some cards carry the answer. Others provide context, atmosphere, timing, contrast, or movement. Treating every card as equally load-bearing can flatten the reading and make the answer harder to hear.

Use these questions while reading.

- ☐ Which cards are actually carrying the answer?

- ☐ Which cards are contextual rather than central?

- ☐ Has a complete cluster already formed?

- ☐ Is another card needed, or is another card being used to delay trusting the answer?

- ☐ Is the next pull adding new information or repeating what is already present?

- ☐ Is the reading becoming deeper, or merely more complicated?

- ☐ If the reading stopped here, what would the clearest answer be?

READER NOTE

Not every card is asking to be heard with equal force. Some cards speak. Some cards support. Some cards simply mark the path already taken.

STAGE THREE · CLOSING THE READING

Has the Reading Landed?

A reading is not complete because a clock runs out.

A reading is not complete because a clock runs out or because a planned number of cards has been pulled. A reading is complete when the question has been met, the answer has landed, and anything further would become padding rather than service.

Use these questions when the reading feels close to completion.

- ☐ Has the central point of the reading been said clearly?
- ☐ Is the reader recapping for the seeker, or repeating from uncertainty?
- ☐ Is silence now more useful than another explanation?
- ☐ Has the seeker received enough to act, reflect, or understand?
- ☐ Is the urge to continue coming from the reading, the reader, or the seeker?
- ☐ Would another card change the answer, or only decorate it?
- ☐ Does the reading feel complete?

READER NOTE

A good ending does not always feel dramatic. Sometimes completion is quiet. The skill is recognising when the reading has reached that quiet and not talking past it.

WORKSHEET

Self-Assessment

Use this after a personal reading or client reading.

Reading Context

Date

Personal or for another person?

Question asked

Question Check

What was the spoken question?

What was actually being sought?

Did the question shift during the reading?

What assumption was hidden inside it?

Card Weight Check

Which cards carried the most weight?

Which cards were contextual?

Did a cluster form? If yes, where?

Was there a point where the answer had already arrived?

Clarifier Check

Were additional cards pulled?

If yes, why?

Did they add clarity, texture, repetition, or noise?

What would the reading have said if it had stopped earlier?

Completion Check

When did the reading feel complete?

Was anything added after that point?

Was the ending clear, rushed, padded, or unresolved?

What would a cleaner ending have looked like?

One Insight to Carry Forward

The next time I read, I want to remember:

